



CRESTED GECKO · CORRELOPHUS CILIATUS

The reptile you can overheat, and how not to.

A complete, fact-checked printable manual: the vertical enclosure, the 85°F ceiling, the daily humidity cycle, UVB (ultraviolet B) light, complete-diet feeding, handling, health triage, the law in every state, and the routines that keep a crested gecko thriving for its full lifespan.

INSIDE

- ✓ Temperature ceiling and humidity cycle in Fahrenheit and Celsius
- ✓ Complete diet, insect and safe-fruit charts
- ✓ Bone disease, floppy tail and blockage triage, plus a symptom table
- ✓ Owner logs, a pet-sitter sheet, and heat-wave and outage plans

48 pages

Beginner

Print or tablet

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CONTENTS

What's inside

Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

GETTING STARTED

How to Use This Package	3
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SECTION 01 · PROFILE

Quick Profile & Cost Overview	4
The Species, Morphs, Size & Lifespan	5

SECTION 02 · HOUSING & ENVIRONMENT

The Vertical Enclosure & Where It Goes	6
Temperature, the 85°F Ceiling & Heat Control	7
The Humidity Cycle, Misting & Airflow	8
UVB Light & the Day Length	9
Substrate, Furnishings & Bioactive Setups	10
Cleaning & Hygiene	11

SECTION 03 · FEEDING

Diet & Feeding by Age	12
Complete Diet Powder: Mixing, Rotation & Refusals	13
Feeder Insects & Gut-Loading	14
Fruit, Treats & the Never-Feed List	15
Calcium, Vitamin D3 & the Supplement Jar	16
Growth, Weight & Body Condition	17

SECTION 04 · HANDLING & BEHAVIOR

Handling & Taming	18
Body Language & Normal Behavior	19
Enrichment & Common Mistakes	20

SECTION 05 · ARRIVAL & LIFE STAGES

Choosing a Gecko, Quarantine & the First Vet Visit	21
Sexing & Females That Lay	22
Egg Binding	23
Shedding & the Winter Slowdown	24

SECTION 06 · THE LAW

Is a Crested Gecko Legal Where You Live?	25
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SECTION 07 · HEALTH & COMMON ISSUES

Red Flags & Finding a Vet	26
Metabolic Bone Disease	27
Floppy Tail Syndrome & Tail Loss	28
Stuck Shed, Respiratory Infection & Skin Trouble	29
Impaction, Parasites & Overheating	30
Reading Droppings, Urates & Hydration	31

SECTION 08 · QUICK REFERENCE

Setup Checklist & Targets	32
Emergency & Quick Targets Card	33

SECTION 09 · OWNER TOOLS

Budget: Setup & Shopping List	34
Budget: Monthly Costs	35
First 30 Days	36
Symptom Quick Reference	37
Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine	38
Heat Waves, Power Outages, Travel & Transport	39
Pet-Sitter Sheet	40
Owner Log	41
Equipment & Vet Log	42
Enrichment Checklist & Log	43

REFERENCE

Glossary, A to G	44
Glossary, H to Z	45
Sources	46
Where the Sources Disagree	47
Version History & About	48

START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

UNITS USED THROUGHOUT

Every temperature and size is given twice. Temperatures appear in degrees Fahrenheit (°F) with degrees Celsius (°C) beside them. Sizes appear in inches (in) and feet (ft), with centimeters (cm) beside them. A gecko and its weight log are measured in grams (g), the unit a small kitchen scale shows. Humidity is a percentage (%) of the moisture the air could hold. Food portions are in teaspoons (tsp), bulbs in watts (W), the measure of power they draw, and prices in United States dollars.

If you haven't set up yet

Check the law first, on page 25: a crested gecko is legal without a permit in most of the United States, but not everywhere. Then read pages 4 to 11 in order before buying anything. Two decisions shape everything else: how tall the enclosure is, and how you will keep it under 85°F (29°C) in the hottest week of the year. Then use the Budget & Shopping List on page 34 to buy once.

If your gecko is already home

Audit what you have against the Setup Checklist in the print list below, and go to the Red Flags page (page 26) if anything seems off. Read the top-of-enclosure temperature and both daily humidity readings first: most of the health problems in Section 07 trace back to heat, humidity, calcium or substrate.

Print these first

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Page 32: Setup Checklist & Targets | ☐ Page 40: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Page 33: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 41: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 37: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 42: Equipment & Vet Log |
| ☐ Page 38: Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine | ☐ Page 43: Enrichment Checklist & Log |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

Most reptile advice is about providing enough heat. With a crested gecko the danger runs the other way: a summer afternoon in a sunny room is a bigger risk than a cool night. This package is cross-checked against the sources listed on page 46.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

A reptile-experienced veterinarian. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care. Anything urgent or health-related is always a vet call, not a page in this book. Find a reptile vet before you need one and write the number on the emergency card. Nothing on the law page is legal advice either.

SECTION 01 • PROFILE

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Correlophus ciliatus</i> , formerly <i>Rhacodactylus ciliatus</i>
Adult size	7 to 9 in (18 to 23 cm) including the tail
Captive lifespan	15 to 20 years, with the earliest known captives living into their 30s
Native range	Southern New Caledonia, in the South Pacific: rainforest canopy and understory
Diet type	Fruit, nectar, pollen and small invertebrates in the wild. In captivity a complete crested gecko diet powder (CGD) is the staple, with insects as a supplement (page 12)
Enclosure minimum (adult)	18×18×24 in (46×46×61 cm), the 24 in as height. Taller is better
Temperature ceiling	85°F (29°C) anywhere in the enclosure. A hard maximum, not a target
Humidity	A daily swing: 80% or higher after the evening mist, 60 to 80% overnight, drying to 45 to 50% by late afternoon
Handling difficulty	Easy once settled, but a dropped tail never grows back (page 18)
Conservation status	Vulnerable on the Red List of the IUCN (International Union for Conservation of Nature)

Cost overview

Initial setup

\$360 to \$595 for the equipment, plus \$65 to \$210 for the first vet exam and fecal test (a stool check for parasites): \$425 to \$805 before the gecko. Most normal geckos sell for under \$100. Every line is on page 34.

Monthly ongoing

\$40 to \$60 for diet powder, insects, calcium, substrate, electricity, and the bulb and yearly vet visit, averaged.

BUDGET FOR THE WORST CASE TOO

A routine exotic vet visit runs about \$40 to \$70, but advanced imaging for an injury or egg binding can pass \$1,000. Neither is likely if you follow this package, but plan for it.

Fun facts worth knowing

- Thought extinct until 1994, when a private expedition found it again on New Caledonia's Isle of Pines after a tropical cyclone. Every pet crested gecko descends from the few animals exported after that.
- The tail never grows back once dropped, and most wild adults have already lost theirs. Its tip carries the same sticky gripping hairs as the toes.
- One of the few reptiles whose complete nutrition comes out of a jar: a powdered diet mixed with water supplies protein, fruit, calcium and vitamin D3 in one.

The species, morphs, size & lifespan

What you are buying, how big it gets, and how long it stays.

One species, from three forests

The crested gecko is *Correlophus ciliatus*, named for the eyelash-like crests over its eyes. It is endemic to the far south of New Caledonia, in the South Pacific, in three separate populations: one on the Isle of Pines and its islets and two on the main island, Grande Terre. It lives in the lower canopy and understory of rainforest, sleeps through the day in secure spots high in the branches, and comes out at night to move, often by jumping long distances from branch to branch. It is arboreal, a tree-dweller: sticky toe pads let it climb glass easily, and a semi-prehensile tail, one that can grip, helps it hold on.

Older books and some state laws still call it *Rhacodactylus ciliatus*. A 2012 revision of the New Caledonian geckos moved it into its own genus, *Correlophus*, and out of the genus it shared with the gargoyle gecko. The two are close relatives with one difference worth knowing, covered on page 28: a gargoyle gecko grows a dropped tail back, and a crested gecko never does.

Lost and found

The species was considered extinct for much of the twentieth century. In 1994 a private expedition rediscovered it on the Isle of Pines, after a tropical cyclone that year led to a sighting, and a small number of animals were exported for study before New Caledonia stopped issuing permits. Every crested gecko in the pet trade descends from those few founders, bred out through separate lines in Europe and the United States. It breeds readily in a terrarium, so the trade is entirely captive-bred.

Morphs

A morph is a captive-bred line that looks different from the wild type: a different color, pattern or crest. The care in this package is the same for every morph. Most normal and patterned geckos sell for under \$100 and standard morphs top out around \$200, while rare and specialty morphs from established lines run upward of \$1,000.

Size and lifespan

Adult length	7 to 9 in (18 to 23 cm) including the tail. A tailless adult is shorter and otherwise normal.
Growth	Tracked by weight in grams rather than length. Hatchlings stay in a small grow-out enclosure until about 12 to 13 g; males show their sex at 18 to 25 g. The milestones are on page 17.
Captive lifespan	15 to 20 years, and the earliest known captives have lived well into their 30s. Wild lifespan has never been studied.

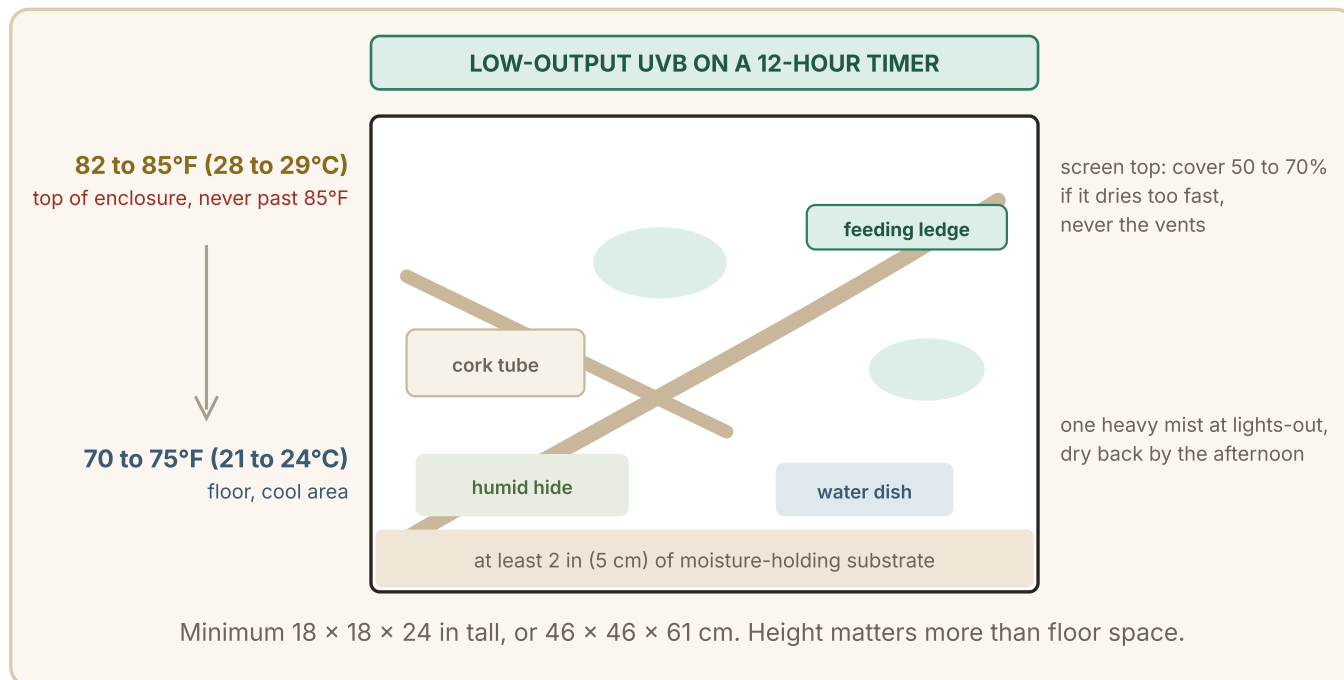
A DECADES-LONG PET

A gecko bought for a child can still be in the house when that child leaves home. Plan for the whole span: the setup you buy now should be one you are comfortable maintaining for decades, with a reptile vet for every one of those years.

The vertical enclosure & where it goes

18×18×24 in (46×46×61 cm) is the minimum for one adult, with the 24 in as height, and taller is genuinely better: a 2×2×2 ft (61×61×61 cm) enclosure is the common upgrade. A crested gecko is arboreal, so height matters more than floor space. Front-opening glass or PVC (polyvinyl chloride, a rigid, waterproof plastic) holds humidity better than a top-opening tank.

Hatchlings under about 12 to 13 g do better in a smaller grow-out enclosure first, where they find food easily and you can find them. A 12×12×12 in (30×30×30 cm) terrarium is the standard hatchling size. Move up to the adult enclosure once the gecko passes that weight and is feeding reliably.



NEVER

House two males together: they fight badly enough to injure or kill. Don't group hatchlings either, which bite each other's tails, and those tails never grow back. One gecko per enclosure. Even two females need at least double the space of an 18×18×36 in (46×46×91 cm) enclosure, plus their own dishes and hides.

Where it goes

- Out of direct sun. A glass box in a sunny window traps heat, and for this species too much heat is a bigger danger than too little.
- Out of the kitchen and away from anywhere food is made or served.
- In a room that sits at 72 to 78°F (22 to 26°C) by day. Many homes already do, which is why many setups need no heat at all.

What the diagram doesn't show

- Height only counts once it is furnished. A tall enclosure with a bare, empty vertical space is missing the part the gecko uses most.
- Anchor every branch and piece of cork. A perch that collapses mid-jump is a fall, or a dropped tail.

Temperature, the 85°F ceiling & heat control

Most reptile keeping is about adding heat. This species is the exception.

ZONE	TARGET (°F)	TARGET (°C)
Ambient air, daytime	72 to 78	22 to 26
Top of the enclosure (the warm area), at the surface	82 to 85	28 to 29
Floor, the cool area	70 to 75	21 to 24
Night	65 to 72	18 to 22
Hard maximum, anywhere	85	29
Too cool: warm area still at or under this at midday, day after day	72	22

The ceiling is the whole story

A crested gecko's home forest in New Caledonia only reaches 79 to 85°F (26 to 29°C) even in the hot season, and prolonged exposure above that risks fatal heat stroke. Too much heat is the bigger practical danger with this species, and it catches out keepers coming from a bearded dragon or a leopard gecko. Cold is the milder failure: temperatures at or below about 72°F (22°C) for long stretches, day and night, bring on lethargy and a dropped appetite.

If the room runs cool

Add a low-wattage heat bulb, 25 to 40 W, in a dome over one part of the screen top, so the top branches reach the warm range and the floor stays cooler. Keep every lamp at least 4 to 6 in (10 to 15 cm) above the highest point the gecko can reach, with the screen between them. A heat bulb alone drifts, so any heat source runs on a thermostat. A dimming or proportional thermostat, which eases the power down as the target nears instead of switching fully on and off, is the type that holds a ceiling this strict. If the room already holds the range, no heat source is needed, and then no thermostat either.

The probe and the gauges

- **The probe reads at the gecko's level**, on or beside the top branches, never up near the bulb, and wherever your controller's manual puts it. Hold it with a probe clip or suction cup, never tape: tape over a probe throws off the reading, and a gecko can stick to exposed adhesive.
- **A digital probe thermometer and hygrometer** (humidity gauge), never a dial gauge. Read the top of the enclosure daily: that is the number the ceiling applies to.
- **Plan for the failure.** A probe that slips keeps showing an accurate reading for the wrong spot, so check its position at every spot clean. A thermostat stuck on has no ceiling at all: a thermometer apart from the probe that reads well above the thermostat's display is the warning.
- **Test first.** Run the whole setup for a day or two before the gecko goes in, and confirm the top reading stays under 85°F (29°C) through the warmest part of the day.

ANY READING OVER 85°F (29°C)

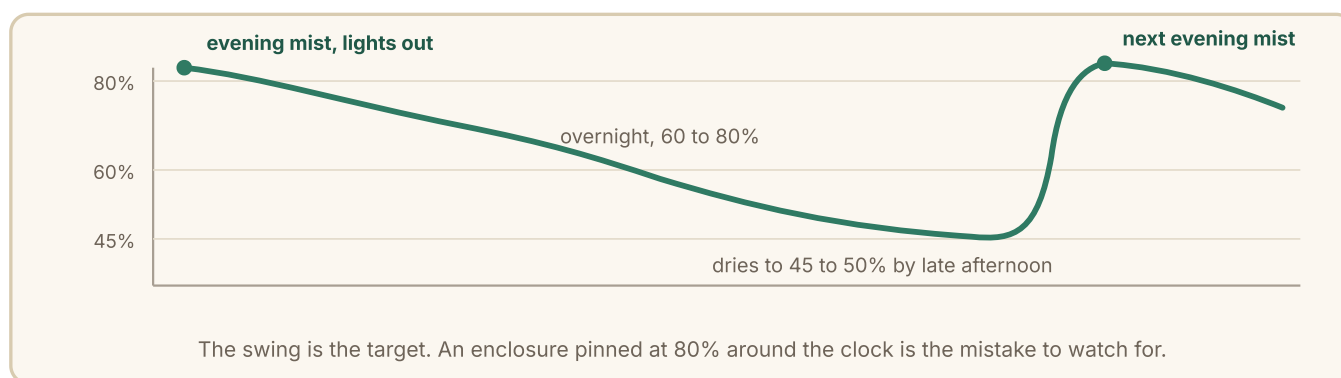
Turn the heat source off now, then find out whether the bulb, the thermostat or the room did it. In summer the room itself can do the heating, and a thermostat can switch a bulb off but cannot cool anything. The heat-wave plan is on page 39.

The humidity cycle, misting & airflow

Wet nights, drier days. The shape of the day matters more than the average.

Aim for 60 to 80% relative humidity overnight, with 70 to 80% the ideal band inside it. The number that matters is not the average but the daily swing: humidity spikes right after the evening mist, holds high overnight, and falls through the day before you mist again. That wet-dry cycle copies the forest and keeps mold and respiratory trouble away.

TIME	TARGET
Right after the evening mist	80% or higher
Overnight	60 to 80%
Late afternoon, before the next mist	45 to 50%



Holding the cycle in practice

- **One heavy mist at lights-out does most of the job.** Soak the walls, leaves and substrate, not the gecko, until droplets bead on the glass. If you need to mist several times a day, something else in the setup is leaking humidity.
- **Read the hygrometer twice:** after the evening mist and again in the late afternoon, with the probe mid-enclosure, away from where you spray. Those two readings tell you whether the cycle is working. Dial gauges drift and read wrong in moist air.
- **Dries out too fast?** A screen top releases humidity quickly: cover 50 to 70% of it with glass or acrylic, but never block the vents entirely. Live plants give off moisture of their own, which smooths the swing, and a room humidifier helps in a dry winter.
- **An automatic mister** removes the inconsistency of hand spraying once it is dialed in. Check it against the hygrometer for the first few weeks.

TOO HIGH IS A PROBLEM TOO

An enclosure that never dries grows mold on the substrate and decor, and cutting ventilation to hold humidity in frequently causes skin and respiratory disease. Mold, or droplets that never clear between mistings, means mist less and open the vents rather than seal the enclosure tighter; a small fan across the top helps if the air is stagnant.

UVB light & the day length

Not strictly required, because the diet carries vitamin D3. Still worth providing, at a low level.

UVB light on the skin is how a reptile makes vitamin D3, and without D3 it cannot use the calcium it eats. A crested gecko on a complete diet powder gets its D3 from the food, so UVB is not strictly required. Low-level UVB is still a solid idea for overall health, and it is one of the three things that prevent metabolic bone disease (page 27). This is a gecko that spends its days in leaf shade, so the right light is a weak one.

SETTING	NUMBER
Tube	A 24 in (61 cm) low-output T5 HO tube in the 5.0 range. T5 is the slim fluorescent tube size, 5/8 inch across, and HO means high output, the tube format; the low rating is what keeps it gentle.
Strength at the gecko	A UVI (ultraviolet index, the standard scale for UVB strength) of about 0.6 to 1.4 at the warm area near the top, falling to 0 to 0.7 across the rest of the enclosure.
Day length	12 hours on, 12 hours off , on a plug-in timer. No colored night bulbs.
Replace the tube	Every 6 to 12 months , depending on the model, even if it still lights. Write the date on the equipment log.

Why so low

UVB needs are graded by Ferguson Zone, four groups that match a species' natural sun exposure to a UVB strength. Crested geckos are Zone 1, the shade dwellers active at dusk and after dark, which is the lowest of the four. Matching the zone matters more than buying the strongest tube on the shelf.

DISTANCE AND GLASS CHANGE THE DOSE

UVB falls off sharply with distance, so mount the tube at the distance its maker's chart gives for this strength. Screen mesh between the tube and the gecko cuts output substantially, and glass or clear plastic blocks most of it, so a tube on a glass lid or a gecko by a sunny window gets far less than it seems to. Mount the fixture over open mesh.

The tube that still glows

UVB output decays months before the visible light dies, so a year-old tube that "still works" is often decorative. That is why it is replaced by the calendar rather than when it looks tired.

LIGHT NEEDS SHADE BESIDE IT

The gecko should be able to get fully out of the light. Dense leaves and cork around the top of the enclosure let it choose between shade and a little light, the same way it controls its own heat by moving.

Substrate, furnishings & bioactive setups

Substrate

CHOICE	VERDICT	NOTES
Paper towel	SIMPLE	Right for hatchlings and quarantine: nothing to swallow, and droppings show at a glance. Replace whenever soiled
Coconut fiber or sphagnum	GOOD	Holds humidity far better than paper. At least 2 in (5 cm) deep, spot-cleaned daily, fully changed monthly
Bioactive soil mix	GOOD	A living floor with a cleanup crew (below). Changed every 3 to 4 months rather than monthly
Sand or bark chips	NEVER	Loose substrate swallowed with food is a leading cause of impaction, a gut blockage (page 30), and a young gecko is most at risk.

Furnishings checklist

- ☐ Branches, vines and bamboo at many heights, mostly thin, a few thick, run diagonally so the gecko can travel floor to ceiling without touching glass
- ☐ Cork tubes, birdhouse-style or magnetic wall hides in the top third, where it sleeps, with at least two at different heights
- ☐ Dense foliage, live or good artificial, for daytime cover
- ☐ An elevated feeding ledge: crested geckos eat off the ground
- ☐ A humid hide lined with damp sphagnum moss, separate from the sleeping hides above and at any height
- ☐ A shallow water dish, though most drinking is droplets licked off leaves and glass
- ☐ Real gaps between perches: open space is where the jumping happens

Plants

Plants do three jobs here: cover, climbing, and drinking water, since live leaves collect droplets after misting. Bromeliads such as *Guzmania* and *Vriesea*, pothos, philodendron, snake plant, bird's nest fern and *Ficus* are gecko-safe choices. Live plants need a 6500 K (kelvin, the scale for the color of light) full-spectrum plant light to survive. High-quality artificial plants give the same cover and still hold mist.

Bioactive setups

A bioactive enclosure has a drainage layer, a soil mix and leaf litter, worked by a cleanup crew of springtails and isopods, tiny invertebrates that break down waste. It adds continuous low-level stimulation and cuts how often you intervene. It is a long-term option once the basics are dialed in, not a requirement to get started. It changes the floor and the cleaning, nothing else: the heat ceiling, the humidity cycle and the diet stay exactly the same.

Cleaning & hygiene

Cleaning removes the waste. Disinfecting kills what is left. Hygiene keeps it off your hands.

SALMONELLA

Healthy reptiles carry *Salmonella* bacteria in the gut and shed them in their droppings without being ill, on and off, and one negative test clears nothing. It travels from the gecko, its enclosure and anything it touches to hands, then to mouths or food, so wash with soap and running water after every contact. Do not kiss the gecko or hold it to your face. Children under 5 should not handle the gecko or touch its enclosure at all. Adults over 65, pregnant people and anyone with a weakened immune system are at higher risk too. A federal investigation into infections linked to pet geckos, closed in January 2026, counted 113 cases and 31 hospitalizations across 36 states.

Three clocks

WHEN	WHAT TO DO
Daily	Empty, wash and disinfect the water dish and the food dish, then refill the water fresh. Crested geckos feed at night, so the morning is when leftover diet comes out. Pick up droppings, uneaten food and shed skin.
Weekly	A non-bioactive enclosure gets a full clean and disinfect at least once a week, more often if more than one gecko shares it: glass, walls, decor and ledges.
Monthly	Move the gecko to a secure temporary tub. Take everything out, scrub it with detergent and hot water, disinfect, rinse, dry, and put in all-new substrate.

A bioactive enclosure skips the weekly and monthly strip-downs and relies on the cleanup crew, with its substrate changed every 3 to 4 months. The dishes still get their daily wash.

Disinfecting, step by step

- **Scrub first.** A film of waste shields bacteria from disinfectant, so it only works on a surface already cleaned.
- **Dilute household bleach 1:32**, which is half a cup of bleach per gallon of water.
- **Keep it wet for at least 10 minutes.** Bleach needs that long in contact to work, so don't wipe it straight off.
- **Rinse until no bleach smell remains**, then let the enclosure and every item dry completely and air out before the gecko goes back in. Plan on a full day of airing.

NEVER THE KITCHEN SINK

Never wash the gecko, its dishes, decor or enclosure in a kitchen sink, a bathroom sink, or a bath people use, or anywhere food is prepared. Keep a plastic tub for the job, or work in a utility sink or outdoors. If a bathtub does get used, clean it thoroughly afterward. Wash decor and gear separately from anything used for food, and keep the gecko out of the kitchen entirely.

If someone in the house gets sick

The signs are ordinary ones: diarrhea, fever, stomach cramps. That is why the link gets missed. Tell the doctor there is a reptile in the house, even if nobody remembers touching it, since enclosure surfaces are enough on their own. It matters most for a child under 5, an adult over 65, someone pregnant, or someone with a weakened immune system, in whom the infection can spread beyond the gut.

SECTION 03 · FEEDING

Diet & feeding by age

The powder is the meal. Insects are the extra.

The biggest feeding mistake with this species is not a wrong schedule. It is treating live insects as the main event, when the complete crested gecko diet powder is the nutritional foundation and insects are a supplement for extra protein and the enrichment of hunting. Offer insects before a gecko is reliably eating its powder and it can learn to hold out for them and refuse the complete diet, which is a real route to malnutrition.

AGE	DIET POWDER	LIVE INSECTS	PORTION OF MIXED POWDER
Hatchling and juvenile, 0 to 12 months	Fresh, daily	1 to 2 times a week	About 1/2 tsp
Adult, 12 months and up	Fresh, every 2 to 3 days	About once a week	About 1 tsp

Adjust the portion by how much actually gets eaten.

Timing and placement

- **Evening.** Crested geckos feed at night, so food goes in around lights-out and the leftovers come out the next morning, when the dish is washed and disinfected like every food dish, every day. Offering only what is cleared within about 4 hours is another option.
- **High up.** They eat off the ground in the wild, so the dish sits on an elevated or magnetic wall ledge, not the floor.
- **Insects sized to the eyes.** No insect wider than the space between the gecko's eyes. Anything not eaten within 15 to 20 minutes comes back out, so it can't stress or nip a sleeping gecko overnight.

Water

A crested gecko takes most of its water as droplets licked off leaves and glass after the evening mist, so the mist is the main drink of the day. Keep a shallow dish anyway as a backup, filled with tap, filtered or spring water: distilled water carries no minerals and is not a good sole source. Wash and refill it daily. Water runs on a much shorter clock than food: a crested gecko can go only about 3 days without it.

NEVER FEED

Avocado, rhubarb, citrus fruit, onion, garlic or eggplant. Fireflies, which are toxic. Any wild-caught insect. The full list is on page 15.

POWDER FIRST, THEN INSECTS

Get a new gecko reliably eating its complete diet before offering any live insect. Insects are the extra in both directions: the gecko does not need them to be well fed, and they cannot replace the powder.

Complete diet powder: mixing, rotation & refusals

The base of the diet. Get this right and the rest of the food pages are extras.

A complete crested gecko diet powder is a meal replacement: mixed with water, it supplies protein, fruit, calcium and vitamin D3 in one product. That is unusual among reptiles, and it is why most health problems in this species trace back to the setup rather than to the food. Several established brands make one.

Mixing and serving

- **Consistency:** mix with water to a smooth, ketchup-like texture.
- **Rotate 2 to 3 flavors or brands**, both for variety and because crested geckos can be genuinely picky. A watermelon flavor has unusually high acceptance among fussy eaters.
- **Serve high**, in a small dish on a ledge, at about 1/2 tsp for a juvenile and 1 tsp for an adult.
- **Fruit alongside, never instead:** fed too often, fruit teaches a gecko to reject the food that is actually complete.

Why a crested gecko stops eating

CAUSE	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE, AND WHAT TO DO
Picky eating	Refuses one flavor or texture, readily eats another. Rotate brands or flavors. Not a health concern
Shedding	Appetite dips for a few days before and after, sometimes up to about a week in total. Wait it out (page 24)
A gravid female	Carrying eggs: plump and less active, off food for a week or more. Lay box in (page 22)
New home or stress	A new enclosure, too much handling, loud noise or other pets. Leave it be while it adjusts
Seasonal slowdown	Eats and moves less in winter even with stable care. Not brumation; weigh it every few days
Wrong husbandry	Heat above about 85°F (29°C), humidity that never rises after the mist or never drops by afternoon, or an undersized enclosure. Check the readings first
Dehydration	Lethargy and wrinkled, loose-looking skin. Fix the evening mist (page 31)
Illness	Mouth rot, parasites, respiratory infection, impaction, or metabolic bone disease. A vet visit
Egg binding	Not a normal pre-laying dip: a female that turns weak or strains. Same-day vet (page 23)

WORK DOWN THE LIST IN ORDER

Pickiness is the first thing to rule out, not the last: crested geckos are fussier than most keepers expect. Look at the husbandry next, since heat and humidity outside their ranges both suppress appetite. Only then treat it as a health question; the day counts that decide when are on page 15.

Feeder insects & gut-loading

A supplement for protein and hunting, not the base diet. Commercially raised, gut-loaded and dusted.

INSECT	TIER	NOTES
Dubia roaches	STAPLE	A better calcium balance than crickets, though still calcium-poor on their own
Discoid roaches	STAPLE	Used the same way as dubia roaches
Crickets	STAPLE	Active prey that brings out real stalking. Take out any not eaten within 15 to 20 minutes
Calciworms	STAPLE	Black soldier fly larvae: a good regular feeder
Hornworms	OCCASIONAL	About 85% water. Captive-bred only: wild ones are toxic
Waxworms	OCCASIONAL	About 22% fat: a treat, mostly for a thin gecko
Mealworms and superworms	SKIP	Hard to digest, and linked to impaction
Fireflies	NEVER	Toxic to reptiles. Not a question of how many
Any wild-caught insect	NEVER	Pesticide and parasite risk, however clean the garden looks

Feeding them out

Juveniles get insects 1 to 2 times a week, adults about once at most, fewer if putting on fat. No insect wider than the space between the gecko's eyes. Rather than dropping insects on the floor, release a few into the upper branches after dark, where a crested gecko naturally hunts.

Why gut-loading matters

Feeder insects are a poor calcium source, and the problem is the ratio of calcium to phosphorus, because phosphorus competes with calcium for absorption. The target for a reptile eating insects is roughly 2 parts calcium to 1 of phosphorus, or at least 1:1. Unsupplemented crickets sit near 1 part calcium to 9 of phosphorus. Gut-loading means feeding the insects a calcium-rich diet for 24 to 72 hours before they are offered, so what is in their gut goes into the gecko too.

GUT-LOAD WITH	NOTES
GOOD	A commercial gut-load sold on its calcium content, not one that just says gut-load on the front. Collard, mustard, turnip and dandelion greens, and butternut squash
NOT ENOUGH	Carrot, potato and apple keep insects alive and watered, but do nothing for the calcium ratio
AVOID	Spinach, beet greens and Swiss chard: high in oxalic acid, which binds calcium so it cannot be absorbed

KEEPING FEEDERS

A ventilated tub, not crowded, with the gut-load always available and a calcium-fortified water gel, since insects drown in an open dish. Remove fresh produce before it molds. Feed insects out within a few hours of taking them off the gut-load: they start emptying their gut as soon as the food is gone.

Fruit, treats & the never-feed list

Treats sit alongside the complete diet, never in place of it.

FOOD	TIER	NOTES
Banana, mango, papaya, apricot, peach	OCCASIONAL	Pureed or well mashed, never in chunks, offered alongside the powder
Melon, and berries other than raspberries	OCCASIONAL	The same rule. Occasional, not routine
Raspberries	DISPUTED	Unsettled: they may be high in oxalate, which binds calcium. Page 47 has both sides
Avocado	NEVER	Unsafe for pets
Rhubarb	NEVER	Unsafe for pets
Citrus fruit	NEVER	The acidity is thought to interfere with calcium absorption
Onion, garlic, eggplant	NEVER	All three are unsafe for crested geckos

Why fruit stays occasional

Fruit is not dangerous in itself. The risk is habit: a gecko fed fruit too often starts rejecting its nutritionally complete powder, and then it is living on the part of the diet that carries the least. A small smear alongside the dish, now and then, is a treat. A daily bowl of fruit is a diet problem.

When a refusal becomes a vet visit

A healthy adult at a good weight can typically go about 2 to 3 weeks without eating and be physically fine, but a vet consult is worth considering once the second week passes, especially with visible weight loss. Juveniles have far less reserve: a young gecko refusing food for more than a few days is more urgent than an adult doing the same. Water runs on a shorter clock, about 3 days.

GO REGARDLESS OF THE DAY COUNT FOR

Visible weight loss · a bony spine, hips or tail base · sunken eyes · lethargy or loss of grip strength · a soft or rubbery lower jaw, an early sign of metabolic bone disease.

Weighing at least monthly, and every few days while the gecko is off its food, catches a real downward trend instead of reacting to one skipped meal. The log is on page 41.

THE NEVER-FEED LIST, IN ONE PLACE

Avocado. Rhubarb. Citrus fruit. Onion, garlic and eggplant. Fireflies. Any wild-caught insect. Any insect wider than the space between the gecko's eyes.

Calcium, vitamin D3 & the supplement jar

Calcium builds bone. Vitamin D3 is what lets the body use it. The question is where each one comes from.

SOURCE	WHAT IT SUPPLIES
Diet powder	Calcium and vitamin D3 already mixed in, with everything else a gecko needs. The powder is complete as it comes: the supplement jar is for the insects.
Insects	Very little calcium for the phosphorus they carry. Gut-loading and dusting are what make them worth feeding (page 14).
UVB light	Vitamin D3, made in the gecko's own skin. Optional on a complete powder, still worth providing at a low level (page 9).
The calcium sacs	Two small sacs at the back of the mouth where a crested gecko stores calcium. A laying female draws on them with every clutch.

Dusting the insects

Lightly dust feeder insects with a reptile calcium supplement before each insect feeding. Occasionally skipping a dusting is fine. Dust immediately before feeding, not in advance: powder falls off, and an insect that has sat dusted in a tub for an hour has groomed much of it away. Gut-loading and dusting are separate jobs, not two ways of doing one. Gut-loading improves the insect itself; dusting is the insurance, because gut-load products vary and you can never be sure how much any insect ate.

Laying females

A mature female can lay infertile eggs with no male present, and every clutch draws on her calcium. Keep calcium in her diet, and look at the calcium sacs at the back of her mouth: sacs that shrink noticeably over a season mean her reserves are running down, and a vet should check her.

When calcium is not the answer

A gecko that is gut-loaded and dusted properly and still shows signs of calcium trouble usually has a light or heat problem rather than a calcium one. A gecko too cool to digest properly cannot use calcium it has eaten, and a UVB tube loses its output well before it stops glowing.

THE PREVENTION IS THREE THINGS

A genuinely complete diet powder as the base, calcium on the insects, and low-level UVB. That combination is how metabolic bone disease is prevented in this species.

Growth, weight & body condition

A gram scale is one of the most useful tools you can own for this species.

Crested geckos are tracked by weight rather than length: a gram scale is precise, and a jumpy climbing gecko on a ruler is not. Weigh at least once a month and log it, and every few days while the gecko is off its food or slowing down in winter. A slow loss is often the earliest sign that something is wrong, well before any other symptom appears.

Milestones

WEIGHT OR AGE	WHAT CHANGES
Hatchling, under about 12 to 13 g	A 12×12×12 in (30×30×30 cm) grow-out enclosure on paper towel, diet powder daily
Under about 10 g	Too fragile for routine handling
Past about 12 to 13 g, feeding reliably	Ready to move up to the adult enclosure
About 6 months, 10 to 15 g, roughly 4 to 5 in (10 to 13 cm)	A sub-adult: short handling sessions can begin (page 18)
12 months and up	The adult feeding schedule: powder every 2 to 3 days, insects about once a week
18 to 25 g	A male's hemipenal bulge usually appears. Under that weight with no bulge means unsexed, not female
Adult	7 to 9 in (18 to 23 cm) including the tail. Males about 35 to 45 g; females about 45 to 65 g, more while carrying eggs

Body condition at a glance

HEALTHY

A rounded body with no projecting hips, spine or ribs, a full tail base if the tail is still there, and a strong grip.

UNDERWEIGHT

A bony spine, hips or tail base, sunken eyes, a loose grip on your hand. Check the powder is actually being eaten rather than drying in the dish, then the heat, the humidity and the stool.

OVERWEIGHT

A round or swollen belly with no eggs in it, fat at the base of the legs or along the flanks, less climbing. Usually a high-fat diet or insects too often: cut back on insect meals. It is linked to fatty liver disease and trouble with eggs.

WHEN A WEIGHT CHANGE IS A VET VISIT

Ongoing weight loss across several weigh-ins, or any visible loss in a gecko that is also off its food. Bring the Owner Log: a trend line tells a vet more than a single reading.

Handling & taming

Gentle and easy to handle once settled, with one fact to know before you ever pick one up.

THE TAIL DOES NOT GROW BACK

Unlike a leopard gecko's, a crested gecko's tail never regrows once dropped. Never grab, hold or restrain the tail, under any circumstances. Calm, unhurried handling is what keeps it on (page 28).

Wait, then wait for size

Don't handle a new arrival for about two weeks. Let it settle into the enclosure and start eating normally first. Then wait for size: regular handling begins with a sub-adult or older juvenile, roughly 10 to 15 g, about 4 to 5 in (10 to 13 cm) and 6 months old. A gecko under about 10 g is too fragile for routine handling.

How often and how long

STAGE	SESSIONS
Starting out	About 5 minutes, every other day
Building up	Longer sessions as the gecko stays calm, toward about 15 minutes once it is tame
The ceiling	Under about 20 minutes of handling in total a day, even for a tame adult

Evening works best, since crested geckos are most active at dusk and after dark.

How to do it

- **Let it walk onto your hand** rather than grabbing it.
- **Treadmilling:** as the gecko reaches the edge of one hand, cup your free hand in front of it. It hops from hand to hand on its own, and you never have to hold it.
- **Stay low,** over a bed, a couch or another soft surface. Crested geckos jump readily and without warning, and a fall onto a hard floor can cause real injury.

PUT IT BACK WHEN YOU SEE

Tail-wagging or whipping · squeaking or other calls · erratic jumping · gaping or an open mouth · closed eyes · actively trying to flee. Any one means the session is over. Skittish, rushed handling is exactly what raises the risk of a dropped tail.

Who should hold it

Children under 5 should not handle the gecko or touch its enclosure, because a healthy-looking reptile can still carry *Salmonella* (page 11). Wash hands with soap and running water before and after every session, even a short one. Handling sessions are also when a keeper can check the sex: the gecko has to sit on a flat hand or inside a clear container to be seen from below.

Body language & normal behavior

What a crested gecko is telling you, and which signals are a job for you or a vet.

YOU SEE	IT USUALLY MEANS	DO
Asleep all day, high in cork or leaves; up and moving after dark	Normal. Wild crested geckos sleep high in the branches and come out at night	Nothing. Handle and feed in the evening
Long jumps between perches, or a sudden leap off a hand	Normal. It moves through the forest by jumping	Leave gaps between perches; handle low
Licking droplets off leaves and glass after misting	Normal drinking	Keep the evening mist going
Tail-wagging, squeaking, gaping or eyes closed while held	Stress	End the session calmly
A dropped tail that keeps wiggling	Autotomy, the built-in defense: the tail detaches and wriggles to distract a predator	Keep calm. It will not regrow (page 28)
Hiding and refusing food in the first weeks	Settling into a new home	Leave it be; no handling for two weeks
Dark parts darker and light parts lighter, often when excited	Firing up, a normal color change whose cause is not fully understood	Nothing. It is not a sign of illness
Dull colors, dry-looking skin, off food for a few days	A shed coming	Keep the humid hide damp (page 24)
Eating and moving less in winter	A seasonal slowdown, not brumation	Weigh it every few days
Adult female plump, less active, off food	Gravid: carrying eggs, with or without a male	Lay box in now (page 22)
Open-mouth breathing, discharge from the nose	Respiratory infection	Vet (page 29)

A gecko built for the night

In the wild a crested gecko spends much of its time among thin branches, and there is a reason for it: the much larger New Caledonian giant gecko preys on it, and thin branches help it get away. It grips fine stems well with its toes and with the tip of its tail, which carries the same sticky gripping hairs as the toes. It sleeps by day in secure spots high up, then travels at night, often by long jumps. Almost every good enclosure choice copies one piece of that: height for sleeping, open gaps for jumping, fine perches for moving, and wet leaves for drinking.

QUICK DIFFERENTIATOR

A winter slowdown is a gecko that eats less and moves less while its weight holds. Illness is the same behavior with weight loss, sunken eyes, a weak grip or a soft jaw. The scale is the tell: weigh it, and compare against the log.

Enrichment & common mistakes

Mistakes that cause the most harm

- Heating it like a bearded dragon: a basking bulb with no thermostat, or an enclosure in a sunny window, past the 85°F (29°C) ceiling.
- Making insects the main diet, or offering them before the powder is reliably eaten.
- A tall enclosure with nothing in it. Empty height is space the gecko cannot use.
- Humidity pinned at 80% around the clock, or vents blocked to hold it in.
- Trusting a dial gauge instead of a digital hygrometer.
- Two geckos in one enclosure, or a group of hatchlings.
- Grabbing the tail, or rushing a skittish gecko.
- Fruit as a routine rather than an occasional treat.
- Loose sand or bark chips under a young gecko, or insects wider than the space between its eyes.

Enrichment, by priority

Enrichment comes after the right temperature, the humidity cycle and a properly sized vertical enclosure, never instead of them. In this order:

1. A real climbing network

The single highest-impact upgrade. Mostly thin branches, bamboo and vines with a few thick limbs, run diagonally so the gecko can go floor to ceiling without touching glass. Leave real gaps. It is hard to overdo; the only limit is stability, so anchor everything.

2. Cover where it sleeps

Cork tubes and hides near the ceiling with dense leaves around them, at least two options at different heights, so the gecko picks a warmer or cooler spot and its own amount of light.

3. Plants that hold water

Live or good artificial leaves give cover, climbing and droplets to drink after the mist (page 10).

4. Food it has to find

Insects once or twice a week bring out hunting and stalking that a dish cannot. Release a few into the upper branches after dark, and keep the powder dish on a raised magnetic ledge, where the gecko naturally feeds.

5. A bioactive setup

Springtails and isopods working through soil and leaf litter add ongoing low-level stimulation. A long-term option once the basics are dialed in, not a requirement.

6. Small changes, not overhauls

A sudden total rearrangement of a shy gecko's enclosure causes stress rather than enrichment. Change a branch angle or rotate a plant; leave the core climbing structure and the hides where they are.

Choosing a gecko, quarantine & the first vet visit

Captive-bred, checked over in good light, and in front of a vet within the first 30 days.

Every crested gecko in the trade is captive-bred. A breeder who hatched it can tell you its hatch date, its food, and when it last ate and shed. Buy only where the enclosures are clean and large enough. A rescue typically charges \$50 to \$175, and a "free" gecko from a rehoming post often comes with medical bills attached; neither is a reason to refuse it, but both are reasons to run the full quarantine below. A juvenile sold below the weight where males show their bulge, 18 to 25 g, is unsexed, whatever the listing guesses.

Look before you pay

CHECK	HEALTHY	WALK AWAY OR ASK MORE
Behavior	Aware of its surroundings, a strong grip	Limp, unresponsive, or unable to hold on
Body	Rounded, no projecting hips, spine or ribs	Visible bones or a sunken tail base
Eyes	Clear and alert	Swollen, sunken, cloudy or crusted
Nose, breathing	Dry nostrils, quiet breathing	Bubbles, mucus, wheezing, open-mouth breathing
Vent (the opening under the tail)	Clean	Stained, pasted with droppings, or swollen
Skin	Intact, no old shed left on	Wounds, or rings of old shed on toes and tail tip

Ask the seller: the hatch date; whether it was captive-bred; what it eats and when it last ate; and whether it has been treated for anything. A good breeder answers without looking anything up.

Quarantine: 3 to 6 months

If another reptile already lives in the house, keep the new gecko completely apart for 3 to 6 months. With no other reptile, skip the separation but not the vet visit.

- **A separate room.** Two enclosures on one shelf share the same air.
- **Paper towel, a hide and a water dish.** Paper shows droppings and anything unusual at a glance.
- **Separate tools, and the new gecko last.** Its own dishes and tongs, cared for after every other animal, with hands washed in between.
- **Restart the clock** if anything flags: a positive fecal test, a regurgitated meal, unexplained weight loss. At the end, disinfect everything that touched it.

THE FIRST VET VISIT, WITHIN 30 DAYS

Find and book a reptile vet before the gecko comes home (finding one is on page 26). The first exam records a baseline weight and checks the animal over, and it should include a fecal test. Intestinal parasites can show no outward sign at all, and cryptosporidiosis, a serious, hard-to-treat parasite infection of the gut, is on the list for this species, so bring a fresh stool sample in a sealed bag. That visit is the baseline every later one is measured against.

Sexing & females that lay

Every female owner needs this page, whether or not a male has ever been in the house.

Telling male from female

The only dependable sign is the hemipenal bulge: a male develops a prominent swelling at the base of the tail, just behind the vent, and a female stays flat there. The bulge usually appears between **18 and 25 g**, so a gecko under that weight with no bulge is unsexed, not female. Look from below while it sits on a flat hand or inside a clear container, never by holding the tail. Sexing earlier is possible by looking at the femoral pores, a row of tiny pores on the underside of the thighs, through a magnifying glass, but that method is not always accurate, so an early call stays a guess until the bulge settles it. It matters most when juveniles share an enclosure: unsexed youngsters can turn out to include two males, which fight.

Females lay without a male

A mature female kept alone can still develop and lay infertile clutches, and producing an infertile egg is harder on her than a fertile one. A laying female typically drops two eggs about once a month through the season, which can span much of the year. A female is not ready to breed until at least 12 months old and 40 g, a male until 10 months and 30 g.

- **Signs she is gravid:** a visibly plump body, less activity, and appetite down for a week or more. She may eat less, but she should stay bright and alert.
- **Laid infertile eggs** can simply be removed.

The lay box

Any adult female needs one, whether or not she has ever met a male: a container with a few inches of slightly moist coconut fiber and fir bark, roughly half and half. Put it in as soon as she looks gravid. A female with no suitable place to lay is at higher risk of holding her eggs.

CALCIUM IS THE OTHER HALF

Each clutch draws on her calcium. Keep calcium in her diet through the season, and look at the two small calcium sacs at the back of her mouth: sacs that shrink noticeably mean her reserves are running down, and a vet should check her. The full calcium picture is on page 16.

Egg binding

Dystocia: a female who cannot pass the eggs she is carrying. A same-day vet visit.

Laid eggs are not the concern; the egg that does not come out is. A normal gravid female and one in trouble look alike at first, since both eat less. The line is clear once you know it: a normal gravid female stays bright and alert, and a female with egg binding stops eating altogether and turns weak or lethargic.

SIGN	NORMAL GRAVID FEMALE	EGG BINDING
Appetite	Eats less, for a week or more before laying	Stops eating
Energy	Bright and alert despite eating less	Weak or lethargic
Belly	Visibly plump	Swollen, with straining
Timing	Lays about once a month through the season	Still straining after her expected laying date

CALL A REPTILE VET THE SAME DAY IF

A gravid female stops eating, turns weak or lethargic, or strains with a swollen belly after her expected laying date. Do not wait it out.

Who it happens to

Most reptiles seen by vets for egg binding are single females kept with no male, so the risk applies to every adult crested gecko female, bred or not.

What causes it

- **Low calcium**, the reserve every clutch draws on.
- **Dehydration.**
- **Wrong temperatures or humidity.**
- **No suitable place to lay:** the reason the lay box goes in before it is needed.

What the vet does

A vet confirms it with an exam, gentle feeling of the belly, blood work and X-rays. Unlike mammals and birds, a reptile can hold eggs for weeks or even months past the normal laying window, which makes the urgency easy to misjudge; it is a reason to get a diagnosis, never a reason to wait at home. With no blockage, treatment can mean fluids, calcium, and a hormone injection to start laying. With a blockage from an oversized or misshapen egg, inducing her is unsafe and surgery is needed instead. The longer it waits, the fewer options remain. A lay box that is always available to an adult female, and calcium kept up through the season, are the cheapest prevention there is.

Shedding & the winter slowdown

Two normal changes that look like trouble the first time you see them.

The shed cycle

Shedding, properly ecdysis, is how a reptile grows and clears old, damaged skin. A juvenile sheds every one to two weeks while it grows, an adult about once a month. Each shed runs in three steps:

STAGE	WHAT YOU SEE
Before	Colors go dull and the skin looks dry. The gecko may hide more and refuse food: appetite commonly dips for a few days before and after, sometimes for up to about a week in total.
The shed	The gecko rubs against rough surfaces to start the peel, then works its way out of the old skin.
After	Clean, bright skin. Check the toes, the tail tip and the eyes in good light for anything left behind.

Helping it come off clean

- **A damp humid hide** lined with sphagnum moss. Higher humidity during the shed helps loose skin come away in one piece, and a humid hide gives that without making the whole enclosure permanently damper.
- **Rough surfaces:** cork, branches and textured bark give the gecko something to rub against. A gecko with nothing rough to rub on can fail to shed cleanly even in perfect humidity.
- **The evening mist**, on schedule. A ring of old skin left on a toe acts like a tight band and can cost the gecko the toe. What to do about stuck shed is on page 29.
- **No handling** while a shed is in progress.

The winter slowdown, not brumation

Brumation is the deliberate winter cooling some temperate reptiles go through. Crested geckos are tropical, do not brumate, and should never be put through a cooling cycle. Even so, many crested geckos eat less and move less through the winter months, even with stable husbandry, on their own internal rhythm. The rule that keeps it safe is the scale: during a suspected slowdown, weigh every few days rather than monthly.

SLOWDOWN OR ILLNESS?

A slowdown with a steady weight is a season. A slowdown with a falling weight is a health problem, and so is one with sunken eyes, a soft jaw, a weak grip, or breathing with the mouth open. Check the heat and humidity readings too: a room that has dropped to 72°F (22°C) or below day and night brings on the same lethargy and loss of appetite.

Is a crested gecko legal where you live?

Legal without a permit in most of the United States, with seven exceptions.

All 50 states, the District of Columbia and New York City, which has its own rules: 52 jurisdictions. A pet crested gecko is **legal with no permit in 45, barred in 2, permit-only in 3, and legal on a condition in 2.**

WHERE	STATUS	THE RULE
Hawaii	Barred	Hawaii Administrative Rules § 4-71-6.5 admits only animals on its conditionally approved or restricted lists. The crested gecko is on neither, under either name, so its absence is a ban.
District of Columbia	Barred	District of Columbia Code § 8-1808(j)(1) bars keeping wildlife except seven listed groups, none of them a lizard.
Massachusetts	Permit	321 Code of Massachusetts Regulations 9.01 clears geckos without a permit except species with a rare conservation rating, under 9.01(3). The crested gecko is rated Vulnerable, so it needs a permit, and the state wildlife agency says it will not issue one for keeping a wild animal as a pet.
New Jersey	Permit	New Jersey Administrative Code 7:25-4.3 lists geckos other than the tokay as needing a permit, and 7:25-4.5 covers any other exotic reptile: the individual hobby permit either way.
West Virginia	Permit	West Virginia Code § 20-2-13 bars bringing in or keeping live wildlife from out of state without an importation permit from the director, captive-bred or not. No application is published: ask the state in writing before the gecko crosses the line, and keep the reply.
Maine	Conditional	Cleared with all geckos on the Unrestricted Species List, under "Captive Bred Origin Only." Species rated Endangered or worse are cut; this one is a rung below.
Minnesota	Conditional	Minnesota Statutes § 97A.401, subdivision 8: a lizard from a permitted breeder, or held before 1 August 2021, may be kept as a pet. The breeder permit is not visibly in place, so ask the state wildlife agency.

Legal with no permit: 45 jurisdictions

Alabama, Alaska, Arizona, Arkansas, California, Colorado, Connecticut, Delaware, Florida, Georgia, Idaho, Illinois, Indiana, Iowa, Kansas, Kentucky, Louisiana, Maryland, Michigan, Mississippi, Missouri, Montana, Nebraska, Nevada, New Hampshire, New Mexico, New York State, New York City, North Carolina, North Dakota, Ohio, Oklahoma, Oregon, Pennsylvania, Rhode Island, South Carolina, South Dakota, Tennessee, Texas, Utah, Vermont, Virginia, Washington, Wisconsin and Wyoming.

In eight of them, Colorado, Illinois, Maryland, Michigan, Montana, Nevada, Oregon and Washington, cities or counties may be stricter, so check your local ordinance (a city or county law) too. Michigan asks for a certificate of veterinary inspection on arrival; North Dakota for one plus an importation permit number from its state veterinarian.

WHY A CONSERVATION RATING DECIDES TWO STATES

The IUCN Vulnerable rating, not anything the pet does, is what puts it under a permit in Massachusetts and close to the line in Maine; a reassessment could move either answer. The species is not listed under CITES, the Convention on International Trade in Endangered Species of Wild Fauna and Flora.

NOT LEGAL ADVICE

A summary of state rules read on 1 October 2026 (Maine on 5 September 2026), not legal advice. Rules change: check with your state wildlife agency and your city or county before you buy or move.

Red flags & finding a vet

What to watch for, what to tell the vet, and how to find one before you need one.

CONTACT A REPTILE VET PROMPTLY IF YOU SEE

A soft, rubbery or misshapen lower jaw · weak or floppy limbs, a kinked spine, tremors, or new trouble climbing · open-mouth breathing, wheezing, mucus or discharge from the nose · no bowel movement for a week or more, or a bloated belly with straining · ongoing weight loss, or a bony spine, hips or tail base · sunken eyes with repeated stuck sheds · any neurological symptom · watery stool more than once in a row, or any blood · tissue protruding from the vent, a prolapse · a gravid female who stops eating, turns weak, or strains past her laying date · a gecko that stays limp or unresponsive after the enclosure has been too hot or too cold.

What to tell the vet

- ☐ Both humidity readings: after the evening mist, and late afternoon
- ☐ The highest temperature the enclosure reached, not just today's reading
- ☐ Substrate, and exactly what the gecko eats, including the diet powder
- ☐ When symptoms started and whether they're worsening
- ☐ Last normal bowel movement, and what it looked like
- ☐ Weight trend from the Owner Log, and a fresh stool sample in a sealed bag if you can

Why the setup comes up first

Nearly everything in this section traces back to husbandry: calcium, humidity and substrate. Metabolic bone disease is a calcium and vitamin D3 problem, stuck shed is a humidity problem, impaction is usually a substrate or prey-size problem, and respiratory infection is a cold-and-wet problem. That is why a vet asks about the setup before the symptom.

Finding a reptile vet

Not every practice treats reptiles, and the time to learn that is not during an emergency. The Association of Reptile and Amphibian Veterinarians keeps a find-a-vet directory of its members. Ask a clinic how many reptiles it sees, whether it routinely treats crested geckos, whether it runs fecal tests in house, and who covers reptile emergencies after hours, then write the number on page 33. Bring a new gecko in within the first 30 days, then plan on a yearly wellness exam with a fecal test as a baseline, not just when something looks wrong.

Normal or concerning

NORMAL	CONCERNING
Dull colors and dry-looking skin for a few days, then a clean shed	Shed stuck on the toes or tail tip, or repeated stuck sheds
Eating and moving less in winter, with the weight holding	The same, with the weight dropping
An adult skipping meals for a few days, bright and alert	A juvenile refusing food for more than a few days, or an adult past two weeks with weight loss
Asleep all day high in the cork, active after dark	Limp, gaping or unresponsive after the enclosure has been hot

Metabolic bone disease

MBD, short for metabolic bone disease: progressive, partly permanent once advanced, and close to fully preventable.

What it is: without enough usable calcium, the body pulls calcium out of the skeleton to keep the blood level steady, and the bones soften and bend. The veterinary name is nutritional secondary hyperparathyroidism. **Cause:** a deficiency of calcium or vitamin D3. In a crested gecko that usually means a diet that is not actually a complete diet powder, or not being eaten, insects fed without dusting, or a gecko kept too cool to digest the calcium it does eat. It is progressive, which is why catching it early matters.

STAGE	SIGNS
Early	A soft or rubbery lower jaw, often the first thing an owner notices
Advanced	Floppy or weak limbs; a visibly misaligned jaw; a kinked spine; tremors; difficulty climbing, which in a climbing species shows early, because the gecko simply stops going up

Diagnosis: a vet, through blood work and X-rays. **Response:** if you notice a soft jaw, don't wait to see whether it gets worse on its own; book the vet this week. **Outlook:** caught early and corrected, the outlook is good. Once the disease reaches the advanced stage, some of the damage can be permanent even with treatment, because bone that has been pulled apart does not come back neatly.

THE PREVENTION IS THREE THINGS

Feed a complete crested gecko diet powder as the base, dust the insects with calcium, and provide low-level UVB. That combination makes MBD one of the easiest serious illnesses in this species to prevent.

Where prevention quietly slips

THE WEAK POINT	WHAT GOES WRONG
The powder dish	Served but not eaten: a picky gecko living on insects and fruit is not on a complete diet (page 13)
The insects	Fed undusted, or gut-loaded on carrot and potato, which do nothing for calcium
The UVB tube	Output falls with distance and age, long before the tube looks dim
The temperature	A gecko kept too cool cannot make use of calcium it has eaten, so a cold room undoes a good diet
A laying female	Every clutch draws on her calcium. Shrinking calcium sacs at the back of the mouth are the warning

A VET THIS WEEK, NOT A WAIT-AND-SEE

A jaw that feels soft or rubbery, any tremor, or a gecko that has stopped climbing when it used to. Bring the powder's name, the dusting routine and the UVB tube's age.

Floppy tail syndrome & tail loss

Two tail problems, one of them permanent, and neither the crisis it looks like.

Floppy tail syndrome (FTS)

What you see: the tail hangs over the gecko's head, or sits at an odd angle to the body, when it rests upside down. **Cause:** typically chronic upside-down resting against glass, over a long time. It is sometimes associated with calcium or pelvic problems and occasionally overlaps with metabolic bone disease, though it is not a sign of it on its own. **Response:** a vet visit is worth it to rule out an underlying calcium problem.

Prevention: give the gecko better places to rest than bare glass. A climbing network that runs floor to ceiling without touching the glass, cork and dense leaves high up, and cover where it sleeps all make a flat glass wall the least inviting spot in the enclosure.

Tail loss

Like many geckos, a crested gecko can drop its tail on purpose as a defense, called autotomy. The tail detaches along built-in fracture points and keeps wiggling on its own to distract a predator while the gecko escapes. The drop itself is thought to be painless or close to it.

IT NEVER GROWS BACK

A crested gecko is incapable of regrowing its tail, ever. Its close relative the gargoyle gecko does regrow a tail, and so does a leopard gecko. Once a crested gecko's tail is gone, it is gone for good.

Why it happens

CAUSE	PREVENTION
Fright, rough or rushed handling	Calm, unhurried sessions; never touch the tail
A cagemate	One gecko per enclosure; never group hatchlings
A fall	Handle low over something soft; anchor every perch
Trapped in a lid or door	Check where the tail is before you close anything

Caring for the stump

A dropped tail is not a medical emergency, and the wound closes on its own if it stays clean. Swap any loose substrate for paper towel until the stump has sealed, and change the towel whenever it is soiled. A soft or hard swelling at the stump is the sign of an abscess: if it looks infected rather than drying and closing, that is a vet visit. The tail held fat reserves, so keep a closer eye on weight and hydration from then on.

LIFE AS A "FROG BUTT"

A tailless crested gecko, a "frog butt" to keepers, lives a completely normal, healthy life. Losing the tail does not affect breeding, climbing or overall health, and most adult crested geckos in the wild have already lost theirs. There is no treatment and no regrowth, so prevention is the whole strategy, and a dropped tail is a reason to review handling and housing, not a reason to panic.

Stuck shed, respiratory infection & skin trouble

The humidity problems, from both directions: too dry, and too wet for too long.

Stuck shed (dysecdysis)

Almost always a humidity problem. Old skin sticks around the toes, the tail tip or the eyes instead of coming off cleanly, and a ring left on a toe or tail tip constricts it and cuts off the blood supply. Left alone, it can cost the gecko the toe, and the damage builds up across shed cycles, so one slightly imperfect shed matters less than a pattern of them.

- **Fix the cause first:** correct the humidity cycle and keep the humid hide damp (page 8).
- **To loosen shed already stuck:** a 30-minute soak in water at enclosure temperature, chin-deep at most, in a shallow dish, supervised the whole time. Then work the softened skin off the toes gently with a damp cotton swab. Never peel dry shed.

Low humidity is the most common cause, but it is one of six: low humidity, skin parasites, nutritional deficiencies, infectious disease, nothing rough to rub against, and reduced thyroid function. Repeated bad sheds in a correctly set up enclosure are a vet conversation, not a humidity problem.

Respiratory infection

Caused by an enclosure that is too cold, too wet, or both, which is the failure that follows misting harder to fix a shedding problem. Look for open-mouth breathing, visible mucus or discharge from the nose, wheezing, and lethargy. It needs a vet promptly; it does not clear up with waiting. Fix the husbandry at the same time: restore the daily dry-back to 45 to 50%, unblock the vents, and make sure the enclosure is not sitting at 72°F (22°C) or below day and night.

Skin and scale trouble, and mold

Chronically high humidity combined with poor enclosure hygiene leads to skin and scale problems. An enclosure that never dries grows mold on the substrate and decor, and with it come bacterial and fungal infections. The signs in the enclosure come first: mold on wood or soil, condensation that never clears between mistings, a musty smell.

THE COMMON THREAD

All three are settings rather than bad luck. Stuck shed traces to the humidity cycle and something rough to rub on; respiratory infection to cold and constant damp; skin trouble to damp without cleaning. Any gecko showing one of them should have both humidity readings and the enclosure's daily high checked the same day, because the fix usually lives in those numbers.

Impaction, parasites & overheating

A blockage, the infections a fecal test finds, and the emergency this species has that most reptiles do not.

Impaction

The most common health problem in pet geckos generally, and crested geckos are no exception. It is a blockage in the digestive tract, usually caused by loose substrate such as sand or bark, by prey too large to pass, or by shed skin that was never fully passed.

WATCH FOR	No bowel movement for a week or more, a visibly bloated belly, straining, lethargy, and appetite loss
PREVENT IT	Solid substrate, paper towel or tile, for young geckos, and no insect wider than the space between the gecko's eyes
A MILD CASE	Straining or a missed stool with the gecko otherwise bright: a warm 15-minute soak can sometimes help, then a vet if it is no better in 24 to 48 hours
A VET NOW	A bloated belly, or no droppings for a week or more. A true blockage is not a home job

Internal parasites and cryptosporidiosis

Internal parasites, and less commonly cryptosporidiosis, are both on the list for this species. Crypto in particular is serious and often difficult to treat, which is the practical reason for a fecal test at the first vet visit rather than waiting for a reason, and again at the yearly exam. Intestinal parasites can show no outward sign at all, so a clean-looking gecko is not a clean fecal. Watery stool more than once in a row is the classic sign of a parasite infection in reptiles, and weight loss on a normal appetite is the other. Bring a fresh sample in a sealed bag.

Overheating

This is the emergency a crested gecko has that most commonly kept reptiles do not. Its home forest never gets as hot as a desert lizard is built to tolerate, prolonged exposure above 85°F (29°C) risks fatal heat stroke, and consistent temperatures above it can cause stress as well as heat stroke. The warning starts lower: more than 80°F (27°C) for long stretches is already too warm. The usual causes are a glass enclosure in the sun, a heat bulb with no thermostat, or a room that got away from you in a heat wave.

IF THE ENCLOSURE HAS GONE PAST 85°F (29°C)

An overheating gecko gapes, tries frantically to get out, or goes limp and unresponsive. Move it somewhere cooler, turn off every heat source in the enclosure, and offer a shallow dish of room-temperature water. Cool it gradually: an ice bath, an ice pack against the body, or cold water can make things worse. A gecko that stays unresponsive or barely responsive, or whose breathing is still labored after 10 to 15 minutes of cooling, goes to a vet right away. Then fix the cause, with the heat-wave plan on page 39.

MOUTH ROT AND THE REST

Mouth rot (an infection of the gums and mouth), parasites, respiratory infection, impaction and metabolic bone disease are all real medical causes of a gecko going off its food. When appetite loss comes with any sign from the red-flag list, it is a vet visit rather than pickiness.

Reading droppings, urates & hydration

The earliest free health check you get. Look before you clean it up.

A reptile passes its waste in two parts at once, through one opening, the vent. The solid stool comes with a urate: a white to cream, chalky or paste-like portion that is a reptile's version of urine, made from uric acid instead of liquid. Because a crested gecko eats a fruit-based powder as well as insects, its stool runs softer than a strict insect-eater's, so soft is not automatically wrong.

IT LOOKS LIKE	USUALLY MEANS	DO
A soft, formed stool with a smooth white to cream urate beside it	Normal, well hydrated	Note it in the log and carry on
Watery or completely unformed, more than once in a row	Parasites or another gut infection	Vet with a fresh sample in a sealed bag
Bright red or dark, tarry blood	Bleeding in the gut	Vet
Straining, or a strong smell beyond the usual	A gut or vent problem	Vet
Nothing for a week or more, or a bloated belly	Impaction	Vet now. A single missed stool with the gecko bright: a warm soak, then vet if no better in 24 to 48 hours (page 30)
Urate yellow, orange, hard or gritty instead of smooth and white	Dehydration at least; in a serious case a urate or kidney problem, the chemistry behind gout	More misting, then vet if it persists

How often

Most adult geckos go every few days to about once a week, and juveniles more often, since they eat more often. The number that matters is your own gecko's baseline. A gap well beyond it, or a sudden jump in either direction, is the signal.

Hydration

A rainforest gecko drinks mostly by licking droplets, so hydration and humidity are the same subject here, and a crested gecko can go only about 3 days without water. Urate texture is the fastest daily hydration read you have: smooth and creamy means well hydrated, dry or gritty means act.

- **The evening mist is the main drink of the day.** Coat the leaves, the cork and the glass until they bead.
- **The dish is the backup:** shallow, washed and refilled daily, with tap, filtered or spring water, never distilled alone.
- **The humid hide** stays damp.

SIGNS OF DEHYDRATION

Sunken eyes · wrinkled, loose or sunken skin, or skin with a dry, sandpaper texture · repeated stuck sheds · sticky saliva · lethargy, less activity, and a gecko that stops eating. Correct the humidity cycle first and check the hygrometer rather than trusting the routine; then the vet if the signs stay.

Setup checklist & targets

Essential setup checklist

- ☐ 18×18×24 in (46×46×61 cm) front-opening enclosure, taller if possible (page 6)
- ☐ Digital probe thermometer and hygrometer, never a dial gauge
- ☐ If the room runs cool: a 25 to 40 W heat bulb on a dimming or proportional thermostat, probe clipped at gecko level (page 7)
- ☐ A fine misting bottle, or an automatic mister on a timer (page 8)
- ☐ 24 in (61 cm) low-output T5 HO UVB tube over open mesh, on a 12-hour timer (page 9)
- ☐ Coconut fiber, sphagnum or bioactive substrate, at least 2 in (5 cm) deep (page 10)
- ☐ Branches, vines and cork from floor to ceiling, anchored, with gaps
- ☐ Dense foliage and hides in the top third, a humid hide with damp sphagnum
- ☐ Elevated feeding ledge and a shallow water dish
- ☐ Two or three complete diet powders, and a reptile calcium supplement for insects (page 16)
- ☐ A kitchen scale that reads in grams
- ☐ A plastic tub for cleaning gear, never the kitchen sink (page 11)

Temperature & climate targets

TARGET	°F	°C
Ambient air, daytime	72 to 78	22 to 26
Top of the enclosure	82 to 85	28 to 29
Floor, cool area	70 to 75	21 to 24
Night	65 to 72	18 to 22
Hard maximum, anywhere	85	29
Humidity	80% or higher after the evening mist, 60 to 80% overnight, 45 to 50% by late afternoon	
UVI near the top	0.6 to 1.4, falling to 0 to 0.7 across the rest	
Light cycle	12 hours on, 12 hours off, on a timer. No colored night bulbs	

Before your gecko comes home

- ☐ Enclosure set up and running for a day or two first
- ☐ Top-of-enclosure reading under 85°F (29°C) through the warmest part of the day
- ☐ Both humidity readings checked: after the mist, and late afternoon
- ☐ Climbing structure anchored, foliage in, feeding ledge mounted
- ☐ UVB tube's install date logged (page 42)
- ☐ Reptile vet found and the first exam booked for the first 30 days (page 21)

Emergency & quick targets

CALL A REPTILE VET NOW IF

The enclosure has been over 85°F (29°C) and the gecko is limp, gaping or unresponsive · a soft or misshapen jaw, weak limbs, or it has stopped climbing · open-mouth breathing, wheezing, or mucus · no bowel movement for a week or more, with a bloated belly · ongoing weight loss · any neurological symptom · a gravid female who stops eating, turns weak, or strains past her laying date · tissue protruding from the vent

READING	°F	°C
Top of the enclosure	82 to 85	28 to 29
Floor, cool area	70 to 75	21 to 24
Night	65 to 72	18 to 22
Hard maximum, anywhere	85	29
Too cool: warm area still at or under this at midday, day after day	72	22
Humidity	80%+ after misting, 45 to 50% by late afternoon	
Without food / water	Adult about 2 to 3 weeks, vet after the second with weight loss · water about 3 days	

Your numbers

Reptile vet _____

UVB tube installed _____

24-hour exotic emergency clinic _____

Replace UVB by _____

Gecko's name and hatch date _____

Last vet visit _____

HAVE THIS READY WHEN YOU CALL

Current weight in grams and the last few from the log. Both humidity readings and the highest temperature the enclosure has reached in the last few days. Substrate type. Which diet powder, and when it was last eaten. When the gecko last passed stool. A photo of anything visible. Transport in a ventilated tub with a towel to grip (page 39).

Budget: setup & shopping list

United States retail ranges, last checked October 2026 and rounded to the nearest \$5. Prices move; treat this as a snapshot, not a quote.

INITIAL SETUP	TYPICAL COST
Enclosure, 18×18×24 in (46×46×61 cm) minimum, vertical; check the dimensions before you buy	\$150 to \$200
Low-output UVB fixture about two-thirds the enclosure length (check the length against your enclosure), tube included	\$50 to \$80
Heat bulb and dome fixture, 25 to 40 W	\$20 to \$40
Dimming thermostat	\$30 to \$35
Substrate: coconut fiber, at least 2 in (5 cm) deep	\$15 to \$40
Cork bark hides, climbing branches, and plants or vines	\$45 to \$80
Digital thermometer and hygrometer	\$15 to \$25
Fine misting bottle, or a fogger	\$10 to \$40
First supply of plain calcium for dusting insects	\$5 to \$15
First jar of complete diet powder	\$10 to \$25
Kitchen scale that reads in grams	\$10 to \$15
Equipment, every row added up	\$360 to \$595
First vet exam and fecal test	\$65 to \$210
All-in with the first vet exam, before the gecko	\$425 to \$805

The gecko is extra: most normal and patterned geckos sell for under \$100, standard morphs top out around \$200, and rare morphs run upward of \$1,000. A hatchling can start in a basic grow-out box for around \$20. If the room holds the range, skip the bulb and thermostat; a bulb never runs without one. A UVB tube's wattage is not its length: a slim high-output tube of 24 watts is about 22 in (56 cm) long, 39 watts about 34 in (86 cm), 54 watts about 46 in (117 cm). Match the length in inches to two-thirds of the enclosure.

Budget: monthly costs

What a crested gecko costs to keep each month once the setup on the previous page is in place, on the same rounding.

MONTHLY ONGOING	TYPICAL COST
Complete diet powder (a \$20 jar lasts about 3 months)	about \$5
Occasional live insects	\$5 to \$10
Calcium top-ups	about \$5
Substrate replacement	about \$10
Electricity	about \$5
UVB tube replacement, averaged over the year	\$5 to \$10
Yearly vet care, averaged	\$5 to \$15
Monthly ongoing, every row added up	\$40 to \$60

PLAN FOR, DON'T COUNT ON AVOIDING

A routine exotic vet visit runs about \$40 to \$70, but advanced imaging for an injury or egg binding can pass \$1,000. A second gecko is a second setup, and every adult female needs a lay box whether she is bred or not.

WHERE NOT TO CUT CORNERS

Enclosure height, the climbing structure that makes it usable, a digital hygrometer, and the first vet exam. Low electricity is this species' budget advantage.

First 30 days

Day 1

- ☐ Weigh the gecko in grams and photograph it and the setup for a baseline
- ☐ Confirm the top-of-enclosure temperature and both humidity readings before the gecko goes in
- ☐ Book the first exam with a reptile vet within 30 days, with a fresh stool sample (page 21)
- ☐ If another reptile lives here, set up the separate quarantine room and its own tools
- ☐ Fill in the emergency card (page 33)
- ☐ Start the equipment dates (page 42)

Week 1

- ☐ Hands off: misting, fresh food and a daily look only (page 18)
- ☐ Heavy mist every evening at lights-out; wash and refill the dishes every morning
- ☐ Offer the powder on schedule even if it goes untouched. Still untouched after a few tries? A second flavor before any worry

Weeks 2 to 3

- ☐ Once it is settled, eating, and past about 10 g, start 5 minute sessions every other day
- ☐ Watch for the first shed, and check toes, tail tip and eyes afterward (page 24)
- ☐ Start the Owner Log (page 41)

Week 4

- ☐ Weigh and compare with day 1 (page 17)
- ☐ Offer the first live insects, gut-loaded and dusted, now that the powder is reliably eaten (page 14)
- ☐ Introduce the first enrichment items (page 43)
- ☐ Do the first monthly deep clean, or skip it for a bioactive setup (page 11)

Days 31 to 90

- ☐ Book any follow-up the vet recommended, and act on the fecal result rather than filing it
- ☐ Keep any quarantine running to the full 3 to 6 months before the gecko shares a room, tools or air with another reptile
- ☐ Look back at the Owner Log for any slow drift in weight, appetite or shed quality
- ☐ Fill in the pet-sitter sheet before you need it (page 40)
- ☐ Check the sex once it passes 18 to 25 g, and add a lay box if it is a female (page 22)

Symptom quick reference

SYMPTOM	LIKELY CAUSE	ACTION
Limp, gaping or unresponsive after a hot spell	Overheating	Heat off, out of the hot room; vet right away (page 30)
Soft or rubbery lower jaw	Metabolic bone disease, early	Vet this week; check the powder is eaten (page 27)
Weak limbs, kinked spine, tremors, stopped climbing	Metabolic bone disease, advanced	Vet promptly (page 27)
Tail hanging over the head while resting upside down	Floppy tail syndrome	Vet to rule out calcium trouble; more cover (page 28)
Tail dropped	Fright, handling, a fall, a cagemate	Paper towel until the stump seals; vet if it swells (page 28)
No bowel movement a week or more, or a bloated belly	Impaction	Vet now; a single missed stool, warm soak then vet if no better in 24 to 48 hours (page 30)
Shed stuck on toes or tail tip	Humidity cycle too dry	Soak and damp swab; fix the evening mist (page 29)
Open-mouth breathing, mucus, wheezing	Respiratory infection	Vet; restore the dry-back and airflow (page 29)
Mold, musty smell, condensation all day	No dry phase	Mist less, open the vents (page 8)
Watery stool more than once in a row	Parasites or another gut infection	Vet with a fresh sealed sample (page 31)
Sunken eyes, wrinkled skin, gritty or yellow urate	Dehydration	Fix the evening mist; vet if it stays (page 31)
Refusing the powder, otherwise bright	Pickiness, or heat or humidity out of range	Rotate flavors, then check the readings (page 13)
Juvenile off food more than a few days	Several possible causes	Vet; juveniles have little reserve (page 15)
Eating and moving less in winter, weight steady	Seasonal slowdown	Weigh every few days; no cooling (page 24)
Female plump, less active, off food	Gravid	Lay box now (page 22)
Gravid female stops eating, weak, straining	Egg binding	Vet the same day (page 23)
Weight loss between log entries	Several possible causes	Vet, bring the Owner Log (page 17)

Daily, weekly & seasonal routine

Daily

- ☐ Heavy mist at lights-out, until droplets bead on the glass (page 8)
- ☐ Read the hygrometer after the mist and in the late afternoon
- ☐ Read the top-of-enclosure temperature; never past 85°F (29°C)
- ☐ Powder on the schedule for its age (page 12); leftovers out the next morning
- ☐ Wash and disinfect the food and water dishes; fresh water in
- ☐ Pick up droppings, and look at them first (page 31)
- ☐ Quick check: eyes full, skin smooth, gecko up in the branches after dark
- ☐ If a heat bulb is in use, check the thermostat probe hasn't moved

Weekly

- ☐ Full clean and disinfect, non-bioactive enclosures (page 11)
- ☐ Insects on insect day, gut-loaded and dusted (page 16)

Monthly

- ☐ Weigh in grams and log it (page 41)
- ☐ Deep clean with all-new substrate, non-bioactive enclosures
- ☐ Check every branch and ledge is still anchored
- ☐ Review the Owner Log for slow trends, not single readings

Every 3 to 4 months

- ☐ Bioactive substrate change

Seasonal

- ☐ Summer: plan now for the hottest week of the year
- ☐ Winter: watch the night low, and weigh every few days through any slowdown (page 24)
- ☐ Adult females: lay box in through the laying season (page 22)

Yearly

- ☐ Wellness exam with a fecal test (page 26)
- ☐ Replace the UVB tube by its model's schedule, 6 to 12 months, even if it still lights (page 9)

Heat waves, power outages, travel & transport

For this species the summer plan matters as much as the winter one.

In a heat wave

The ceiling is 85°F (29°C) anywhere in the enclosure, and in summer the room itself can do the heating. Read the top of the enclosure through the day with a digital probe, not a stick-on strip, and check the bottom stays cooler. A thermostat can switch a bulb off but cannot cool anything, so turn the lamp off once the room itself reaches 82°F (28°C). Keep the enclosure out of direct sun, move it to a cooler room if this one climbs, and keep the vents open. A gecko limp, gaping or unresponsive after a hot spell goes to a vet right away.

When the power goes out

A normal night low is 65 to 72°F (18 to 22°C), so one cool night is not an emergency. Act once the room heads for 72°F (22°C) or below day and night, which brings on lethargy and appetite loss.

Do

- A battery thermometer in the enclosure, to read the real number.
- Thick towels over the enclosure, with a vent gap, to hold the heat in.
- Move the enclosure, or the gecko in a ventilated tub, to the warmest room.
- A wrapped hot-water bottle or hand warmer beside the gecko, never touching it.
- An automatic mister stops with the power: mist by hand on schedule.
- No insects until heat is back. Past a day or two too cool, board it with a vet or a friend with power.

Don't

- Don't use candles, gas stoves, or open flame near the enclosure.
- Don't put a heat pack in contact with the gecko; a cold animal can't move away fast enough and will burn.
- Don't feed insects to "keep its strength up." Undigested food in a cold gut rots.
- Don't warm a cold gecko in hot water.

OUTAGE KIT

Hand warmers or a hot-water bottle, two thick towels, a battery thermometer, a ventilated tub, a hand mister, and your vet numbers on paper.

Leaving town

The nightly mist is a daily need, so plan one step stricter than for a typical reptile.

TRIP LENGTH	ADULT	JUVENILE, OR A GECKO SICK, MID-SHED OR GRAVID
1 to 2 nights	A sitter every 1 to 2 days for the mist, water, a stool check and a temperature check.	A sitter daily, with pre-measured powder and written instructions.
3 nights or more	A daily sitter who has done a practice visit with you, or boarding with a reptile-experienced vet or shop. Never a general dog-and-cat boarding facility.	

Transport and vet trips

- A ventilated plastic tub or small carrier with a towel to grip, in a dark, room-temperature bag or box. No loose substrate, no water dish.
- Skip the meal before a trip, and never leave the gecko in a parked car, hot or cold. Below 65°F (18°C), warm the car first, and on trips over about 30 minutes put a wrapped hand warmer beside the tub. Check it every 20 to 30 minutes.

FILL IN AND LEAVE BY THE ENCLOSURE

Pet-sitter sheet

Everything a sitter needs on one page. Walk them through it once in person before the first solo visit.

Gecko's name _____

Age and normal weight _____

My phone _____

Reptile vet _____

24-hour emergency clinic _____

Backup contact _____

Each visit

☐ In the evening, mist the walls, leaves and cork, not the gecko, until droplets bead on the glass.
Misting time: _____.

☐ Read the thermometer and hygrometer and write both down. The top should stay under 85°F (29°C).

☐ Diet powder on these days: _____.
Mix _____ of powder with water to a ketchup texture, in the dish on the ledge.

☐ In the morning, take out last night's food. Wash both dishes and refill the water.

☐ Pick up any droppings and note whether they looked normal.

☐ Wash your hands before and after. Don't rinse anything in the kitchen sink.

☐ Everything is kept: _____.

Please don't

- Take the gecko out, or touch the tail at all. It can drop, and it never grows back.
- Change any dial, timer or thermostat setting, or move the enclosure into a sunnier room.
- Feed anything not on this sheet, and never insects from outside.

CALL ME IF

The thermometer reads above 85°F (29°C), or the gecko is limp or gaping after the room has been hot · the hygrometer doesn't rise after misting · breathing is audible, open-mouthed, or there is mucus at the nose · it hasn't moved from the same spot on two visits · there are no droppings across several visits, or they are runny · anything is protruding from the vent · the tail has come off · anything else looks wrong. If I don't answer, call the vet number above.

Owner log

[illegible]

Weight change is often the earliest sign that something is wrong, well before anything else shows, and on an animal this small a few grams is a lot. A trend line tells a vet more than any single reading. Bring this page to every visit.

Equipment & vet log

Equipment log

ITEM	INSTALLED	REPLACE OR CHECK BY	DONE
UVB tube (6 to 12 months, by model)			
Substrate (monthly, or 3 to 4 months bioactive)			
Mister or fogger timer check			
Thermometer and hygrometer batteries			
Heat bulb and thermostat, if used			
Diet powders and calcium opened			

Twelve-month planner

Tick the box in the month you did it. Month 1 is whichever month you start in.

TASK, BY MONTH	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
Weigh and log	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Deep clean	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Perches anchored	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
UVB tube replaced						☐						☐
Vet exam and fecal	☐											☐

Vet visit log

DATE	WEIGHT (G)	REASON AND FINDINGS	FOLLOW-UP

Enrichment checklist & log

Setup

- ☐ A climbing network from floor to ceiling, mostly thin branches, with real gaps
- ☐ At least two hides high up, at different heights
- ☐ Dense foliage that holds droplets after misting
- ☐ A raised feeding ledge, so the gecko never comes down to eat
- ☐ Lay box for an adult female through the season (page 22)

Monthly review

- ☐ Change one branch angle or rotate one plant. Leave the core structure and hides alone
- ☐ Release insects into the upper branches after dark at least once
- ☐ Rotate to a different powder flavor for a week
- ☐ Try one occasional fruit from the safe list (page 15)
- ☐ Check every perch is still anchored

Enrichment log

DATE	ACTIVITY	HOW IT WENT, AND WHETHER TO REPEAT

ENRICHMENT SAFETY

Anchor everything: a perch that collapses mid-jump is a fall, or a dropped tail that never grows back. Take out insects not eaten within 15 to 20 minutes, never use wild-caught insects, and never overhaul a shy gecko's whole enclosure at once. Nothing here replaces the temperature ceiling and the humidity cycle.

REFERENCE

Glossary, A to G

Arboreal	Tree-dwelling. Why height beats floor space for this species, and why the food dish belongs on a ledge. Page 6.
Autotomy	Dropping the tail on purpose as a defense. The tail breaks at built-in fracture points and wriggles to distract a predator. In a crested gecko it never grows back. Page 28.
Bioactive	A living enclosure with a drainage layer, a soil mix, leaf litter and a cleanup crew of springtails and isopods, tiny invertebrates that break down waste. Page 10.
Calcium sacs	Two small sacs at the back of a crested gecko's mouth where it stores calcium. Shrinking sacs in a laying female mean her reserves are running down. Page 16.
CGD	Crested gecko diet: the complete powdered food, mixed with water, that is the staple of this species' diet, with protein, fruit, calcium and vitamin D3 in one. Page 13.
CITES	The Convention on International Trade in Endangered Species of Wild Fauna and Flora: the treaty that controls international trade in listed species. The crested gecko is not listed. Page 25.
Cryptosporidiosis	"Crypto": a serious, often hard-to-treat infection of the gut by a single-celled parasite. One reason for a fecal test at the first vet visit. Page 30.
D3, vitamin D3	The vitamin a reptile needs to absorb and use calcium. A crested gecko gets it from its diet powder, and makes some in its skin under UVB. Page 16.
Dimming thermostat	A thermostat that turns a heat bulb's power down as the target nears, the way a light dimmer does, instead of switching it fully off and on. Suits a strict ceiling. Page 7.
Dysecdysis	Stuck or incomplete shedding, most often on the toes and the tail tip. Almost always a humidity problem in this species. Page 29.
Dystocia	Egg binding: a female unable to pass the eggs she is carrying. A same-day vet visit. Page 23.
Ecdysis	The normal shed: the whole old skin peeling away so the gecko can grow and clear damaged skin. Page 24.
Fecal test	A vet's microscope check of a stool sample for parasites. Bring a fresh sample in a sealed bag. Page 21.
Femoral pores	A row of tiny pores on the underside of the thighs. Some breeders use them to sex young geckos early, but the method is not always accurate. Page 22.
Ferguson Zone	One of four groups that match a species' natural sun exposure to a UVB strength. Crested geckos are Zone 1, the shade dwellers, the lowest. Page 9.
Frog butt	Keeper slang for a crested gecko that has lost its tail. It lives a completely normal, healthy life. Page 28.
FTS	Floppy tail syndrome: a tail that hangs over the head or sits at an odd angle when the gecko rests upside down, linked to long-term resting on glass. Page 28.
Gravid	Carrying eggs. A female can be gravid without ever meeting a male. Page 22.
Grow-out enclosure	A small enclosure, 12×12×12 in (30×30×30 cm), where a hatchling lives until it passes about 12 to 13 g and feeds reliably. Page 6.
Gut-loading	Feeding insects a calcium-rich diet for 24 to 72 hours before they are offered, so what is in their gut goes into the gecko too. Page 14.

REFERENCE

Glossary, H to Z

Hemipenal bulge	The swelling at the base of a male's tail, just behind the vent, usually visible from 18 to 25 g. The only dependable way to sex a crested gecko. Page 22.
Humid hide	A hide lined with damp sphagnum moss, where the gecko can sit in moist air without the whole enclosure staying wet. Pages 10, 24.
Hygrometer	A humidity gauge. Use a digital one with a probe; dial gauges drift and read wrong in moist air. Page 8.
Impaction	A blockage in the digestive tract, usually from loose substrate, oversized prey, or shed skin that was never passed. Page 30.
IUCN	The International Union for Conservation of Nature, which keeps the Red List grading how threatened each species is. It rates the crested gecko Vulnerable. Pages 4, 25.
K (kelvin)	The scale for the color of light. A 6500 K lamp gives white, daylight-colored light, the kind live plants need. Page 10.
Lay box	A container with a few inches of slightly moist coconut fiber and fir bark, half and half, where a female lays. Every adult female needs one. Page 22.
MBD	Metabolic bone disease: soft, weakened, deformed bones from too little usable calcium or vitamin D3, properly called nutritional secondary hyperparathyroidism. Page 27.
Morph	A captive-bred line that looks different from the wild type in color, pattern or crest. Care is the same for all. Page 5.
Mouth rot	An infection of the gums and mouth, one of the medical reasons a gecko stops eating. A vet visit. Page 30.
Oxalic acid	A compound in spinach, beet greens and Swiss chard that binds calcium so it cannot be absorbed. Why they are the wrong gut-load. Page 14.
Probe	The thermostat's sensor. At the gecko's level, held with a clip or suction cup, never tape. Page 7.
Proportional thermostat	A thermostat that sends power in short pulses to hold a steady temperature, instead of switching fully on and off. Page 7.
PVC	Polyvinyl chloride: a rigid, waterproof plastic used for enclosure panels. A front-opening PVC or glass enclosure holds humidity well. Page 6.
Quarantine	Keeping a new reptile fully apart from others, in a separate room with separate tools, for 3 to 6 months. Page 21.
<i>Salmonella</i>	Bacteria that healthy reptiles carry in the gut and shed in their droppings without being ill. Spread hands to mouth. Page 11.
T5 HO	A fluorescent tube 5/8 inch across (T5), in the high-output (HO) version. A low-output 24 in tube is the right UVB source here. Page 9.
Treadmilling	Letting a gecko walk from hand to hand, cupping the free hand in front each time, so it is never held. Page 18.
Units	°F, degrees Fahrenheit, and °C, degrees Celsius, for temperature; in (inches), ft (feet) and cm (centimeters) for size; g (grams) for weight; tsp (teaspoons) for food; W (watts) for bulbs; % (percent) for humidity.
Urate	The white to cream, paste-like part of reptile waste, made from uric acid instead of liquid urine. Hard, gritty or yellow means dehydrated. Page 31.
UVB	Ultraviolet B: the part of sunlight a reptile's skin uses to make vitamin D3. Glass and clear plastic block most of it. Page 9.
UVI	Ultraviolet index: a measure of UVB strength at one spot. About 0.6 to 1.4 near the top of a crested gecko's enclosure. Page 9.
VCA	VCA Animal Hospitals, originally Veterinary Centers of America: an animal hospital chain whose pet care articles are among this package's sources.
Vent	The single opening under the base of the tail that waste and eggs pass through. Page 21.

REFERENCE

Sources

Where the numbers in this package come from, so you can check them yourself.

Veterinary references

- VCA Animal Hospitals (originally Veterinary Centers of America): reptile dystocia; the new reptile visit; choosing a pet reptile; reptile gout. Egg binding, the first exam, and what a discolored urate warns of.
- Merck Veterinary Manual: management and husbandry, disorders and diseases, environmental diseases and traumatic injuries, reproductive diseases, parasitic and viral diseases, selecting a reptile, routine health care, clinical procedures, and cleaning and disinfection in shelter medicine. Quarantine, ventilation, cold floors and the bleach dilution.
- Maria Zayas, veterinarian, Crested Gecko Care Sheet, PetMD. Long Island Bird and Exotics Veterinary Clinic: crested gecko care guide. Kevin Wright, veterinarian, in Reptiles Magazine: diagnosing and treating retained shed, the 30-minute soak and the six causes. Winter Park Veterinary Hospital: reptile shedding. Chicago Exotics Animal Hospital: crested gecko care, and the heat of a sunny window. South Pasadena Animal Hospital: exotic pets in summer heat, and overheating first aid. Swifttail Exotic Telemedicine Veterinary Services: crested gecko care, and life without a tail.
- Association of Reptile and Amphibian Veterinarians: the find-a-vet directory.

Research

- Gumangan, Pan and Lozito (2024), GigaByte: chromosome-level genome assembly and annotation of the crested gecko, *Correlophus ciliatus*, a lizard incapable of tail regeneration. Permanent tail loss.
- Baines and colleagues (2016), Journal of Zoo and Aquarium Research 4(1): how much UVB a reptile needs, and the Ferguson Zones.
- Finke (2002 and 2013), Zoo Biology: the nutrient content of feeder insects. Klasing and colleagues (2000), Journal of Zoo and Wildlife Medicine, and Allen and Oftedal: raising feeder calcium by diet.

Public health

- Centers for Disease Control and Prevention: Healthy Pets, Healthy People, reptiles and amphibians, and the *Salmonella* Muenchen outbreak linked to pet geckos, closed January 2026. Center for Food Security and Public Health, Iowa State University: reptile- and amphibian-associated salmonellosis, and isolation and quarantine areas.

Husbandry, equipment and the law

- ReptiFiles: the crested gecko care sheet (also as republished by Zen Habitats), temperatures and humidity, enclosure size and cohabitation, food, handling, sexing, tail loss, decorations, and the shopping list; the leopard gecko tail loss page; and the feeder insect nutrition chart. Zen Habitats: humidity and hydration for crested geckos. New England Herpetoculture: crested and gargoyle gecko breeding. Moon Valley Reptiles: crested gecko care. Reptile Craze: not eating, and time without food or water. ScaledKeeper and ReptileCoach: crested gecko health problems and the growth chart. The Vet Desk: crested gecko cost. Zoo Med Laboratories: UVB tube lengths and wattages.
- Enrichment: More Reptiles; Royal Society for the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals, crested gecko advice; International Association of Animal Behavior Consultants Foundation Journal, natural behaviors in geckos; Wikipedia, crested gecko. Spyder Robotics, thermostat manual: probe placement and the warning against tape.
- Hawaii Administrative Rules chapter 4-71; District of Columbia Code § 8-1808(j); 321 Code of Massachusetts Regulations 9.00; New Jersey Administrative Code 7:25-4; Maine Department of Inland Fisheries and Wildlife, Unrestricted Species List; Minnesota Statutes § 97A.401; West Virginia Code § 20-2-13; and each other state's rules, read on 1 October 2026 (Maine on 5 September 2026).
- Beastly Facts guides, current at publication: the crested gecko enclosure setup, humidity, feeding, handling, health issues, enrichment, cost and legal guides, and the cross-species reptile quarantine, heating and thermostats, UVB lighting, emergency plan, stool and urates, gut-loading, *Salmonella* and hygiene, and shedding guides. Prices were last checked in September 2026.

REFERENCE

Where the sources disagree

Where credible sources give different numbers, this package prints one and says why.

TOPIC	WHAT THE SOURCES SAY	WHAT THIS PACKAGE USES
Insect size	No wider than the widest part of the head (a veterinary care sheet); no wider than the space between the eyes (husbandry references)	The space between the eyes, the smaller and safer limit
Mealworms	An occasional treat (a veterinary care sheet); hard to digest and tied to impaction (husbandry references)	Skipped
First vet visit	Within the first 30 days (species health guidance); within 72 hours and no later than two weeks (a reptile vet-visit guide)	Booked before arrival, seen within 30 days; sooner is never wrong
Gut-loading	6 to 12 hours (a veterinary care sheet); 2 to 3 days (husbandry references)	24 to 72 hours
Raspberries	A safe treat (some sources); high in oxalate (others)	Disputed, so left off the safe list
Quarantine	3 to 6 months (veterinary); 60 to 90 days (a hobby floor)	3 to 6 months
UVB tube life	6 to 12 months, depending on the model	The maker's schedule, never past 12 months
Sexing	The hemipenal bulge at 18 to 25 g; femoral pores under a magnifier earlier, not always accurate	The bulge decides
Heat	Never above 80°F (27°C) for long (a veterinary care sheet); 85°F (29°C) as the ceiling (husbandry references and a veterinary hospital)	85°F (29°C) as the hard ceiling, long stretches over 80°F (27°C) as the warning

REFERENCE

Version history & about

What changed in each edition, so a printed copy can be placed.

Version history

This is edition 3.1 (Oct 2026). The store page shows the current edition; re-download free if yours is older. Where this list and a page disagree, the page wins.

- **3.1, Oct 2026.** Costs: every item priced and rounded to the nearest \$5; setup \$360 to \$595, monthly \$40 to \$60, the budget now over two pages. Other changes are wording only.
- **3.0, Oct 2026.** Rebuilt on the current outline, 48 pages. Safety: lamps 4 to 6 in above the gecko, probe clipped, never taped; over 80°F too warm, lamp off once the room reaches 82°F; overheated gecko cooled with all heat off and a shallow dish of room-temperature water, vet if unresponsive or breathing hard after 10 to 15 minutes; one heavy mist at lights-out, humidity 45 to 50% by late afternoon; dish water tap, filtered or spring, never distilled alone; UVB 24 in low-output T5 HO, UVI 0.6 to 1.4, replaced every 6 to 12 months; substrate at least 2 in; hatchlings in 12×12×12 in until 12 to 13 g, handling from 10 to 15 g in sessions from about 5 minutes, sexing at 18 to 25 g; insects no wider than the space between the eyes, gut-loaded 24 to 72 hours, calcium-dusted, no D3 or multivitamin; no mealworms or superworms; hornworms captive-bred only; dishes disinfected daily, enclosure weekly, bleach wet 10 minutes; weigh monthly; dropped tail on paper towel, swollen stump to a vet; lay box half moist coconut fiber, half fir bark; gravid female off food, weak or straining to a vet same day. Legal: a new page, all 52 jurisdictions. Costs: most geckos under \$100, rare morphs from \$1,000; vet visit \$40 to \$70. Other changes are wording only.
- **2.1, Sep 2026.** Safety: quarantine for a new reptile now 3 to 6 months, no longer ended by one clear fecal test; children under 5 kept from handling; a gritty or discolored urate corrected with misting. Other changes are wording only.
- **2.0, Sep 2026.** Rebuilt, 34 pages. Safety: nothing dusted into the complete diet powder.
- **1.0, 2026.** First edition, 21 pages. Replaced by 2.0.

This package is a husbandry reference compiled from the listed sources and cross-checked against current veterinary guidance at the time of publication. It is not a substitute for a reptile-experienced veterinarian, and nothing in it should delay a vet visit. Treatments described here are for recognizing what a vet may do, never for use at home. The law page is a summary as of October 2026, not legal advice.

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